

It's an unhelpful and negative take¹ –I have asked Patrice (dept chair) to rewrite (see appendix), but she didn't, so I respond below. Excuse me bringing up negative things, but I have not brought those up first, just responding here.

1 Difficult Department

The main criticism is I don't get along and keep on suing people. I'm actually shocked they² bring it up, they should be ashamed and keep it quiet, but since they brought it up, let me respond. What happened here is that Gloria offered \$5k for a workshop for her staff, I did the workshop, she didn't pay, so I told her I'll have to sue, then she paid.³ End of story. Why even bring this up? What did I do wrong? I'd be wrong if I didn't sue. And no hard feelings, stuff happens, let's move on. Then suing Mike: he signed merit pay evaluation that's non-factual, it said I "underperform" in "research", while I can prove I overperform (see later under research)–again looks like a clear case to me to sue. Any reasonable person would do the same.⁴ I could elaborate,⁵ but again why you even bring this up? What did you think would happen here?⁶

"Adam also threatened to hold up a PhD student's proposal over a methodological dispute with the committee chair." –yes! It was a poor dissertation. I did my job. What's strange is that Paul kicked me out of the committee, as opposed to fix the dissertation.

Teaching evaluation that I wasn't cooperating with. Paul got this idea that he is my mentor and that I need his advice. He doesn't know much about my research area and giving me bad advice (instrumental variables etc). I'm trying to steer away from him, doesn't work, he needs to force his way. Paul doesn't take it well that I don't listen to his unhelpful research advice. He retaliates by giving me bad teaching evaluation.⁷

¹Many parts are not factual and lacking objectivity. Only some parts are constructive/useful as elaborated later. Still, I find this post-tenure review useful as it hopefully results in better communication and clearer expectations.

²By "they" I mean Gloria and Patrice—as far as I can tell Gloria really runs the department, not Patrice. "On the face of it this is a good record. However, there are underlying problems with Adam's performance. Specifically, Adam has been very contentious in his interactions with faculty in the department." It is not "on the face of it", it is a good record, you didn't have anything else to pick on, so you pick on this. You confuse cause with effect: me being contentious does not cause my poor performance; rather: my good performance causes others to be contentious: they are jealous or something and keep on giving me poor evaluations like zero merit pay and then that in a vicious cycle causes me to be contentious.

³If I made things up, then she probably would not pay, but she did pay. But if there are any slightest doubts on what happened, please let me know and let's dig deeper here. And of course, it was last resort, I did ask first several times for payment.

⁴Of course, last resort, I asked several times to fix this. And then here I actually backed off for 2 reasons—I had a good conversation with the dean who convinced me it's not necessary to sue, and 2) I felt bad for Mike because I'm pretty sure it wasn't him behind this fake evaluation—it was most likely Gloria behind the scenes, Mike just signed it. But keep on pushing me and I will sue. We can go that way. It's ridiculous you even bring this up. Finally, Patrice says I threatened to sue 3 people. No. I think she means one email I sent to her, but I didn't mean her, but Mike who signed the evaluation, and effectively Gloria who was most likely behind the scenes. So it's really just about one person, Gloria.

⁵Adam has been very contentious in his interactions with faculty—I fit right in, everyone is. "threatened to sue 3 faculty members"—no, just one, just Gloria, but she settled so we are all good from my side. No hard feelings. Gloria also seemed to have made Mike sign poor merit pay evaluation for me, so I had to threaten lawsuit there, but it's all about Gloria behind the scenes. And Patrice misunderstood one email, it wasn't about her, but about Gloria. "His threats have strained working relationships in the department."—how? Gloria wasn't talking to me anyway—I haven't strained any relationship with Gloria—it never existed. "This makes it extremely difficult to for Adam to work with faculty members at lower ranks; at the same rank, but with fewer years of service; and even full professors."—I don't think me suing Gloria has anything to do with me working with others, especially junior folks. If anything people should appreciate me seeking justice. There's actually just one junior person, Clint, and we do get along, Clint invited me to be on his grant, we got it, and will be doing research together. It's opposite, it's most difficult to work with full professors in DPPA, not junior. Patrice blames toxic department on me—it was toxic long before I threatened to sue. Suing one person has little to do with other persons, if anything at all. And suing is a good way to seek fairness/justice, which we badly lack in DPPA—if anything I should get award, not be blamed.

⁶I guess it was meant to scare me or something or make me more docile and do what I'm told, like later under Service Patrice says I should work for free for Gloria's and Steve's centers if I understood correctly. But no, I won't be pushed around. But while I have my boundaries, at the same time, I am super friendly, I study happiness after all. Come on DPPA let's move on and let's get along, let's have a beer together:)

⁷I was trying to avoid Paul doing the evaluation—I felt like he's after me. And I had bad experience from past when he would oppose me going up to full unless I listen to his unhelpful research advice so I'd protest: "Paul is not reasonable neither fair in his evaluations," to which he responds "You are charming as always. This evaluation will happen one way or another." Why not just let it go and why being so stubborn to evaluate me? Another reason for not having Paul evaluate my teaching: he had this questionable PhD qualifying exam that was counterproductive for students, so I had at a time a political action/petition with students going on against Paul's cheerished exam. I knew he was rather angry with me upending his favorite exam, so I went to Patrice and explained that there is conflict of interest: I am rallying up students against Paul's favorite exam, and you have Paul evaluate my teaching. Patrice brushed it off. Patrice could have done evaluation herself, could have chosen another associate professor. Actually I did find a great evaluator myself, Bill Fitzgerald from Teaching Matters—Bill did agree to do the evaluation. Again, no, it had to be Paul. Yet another reason I gave to Patrice: the class I was teaching was outside of Paul's expertise, and you'll see in attached evaluation in appendix that Paul didn't understand much of the class. Last but not least, I wouldn't be sure 100% from all of this that Paul was indeed retaliating. But I did confront him after evaluation, I met him in person and told him I felt it was like retaliation, that you were going after me. His face went red. I actually didn't fully expect it! I thought maybe I was overthinking and being paranoid. I mean we're all human, Paul is a good person in general I guess, but come on, really? This is the kind of stuff we have going on in DPPA.

2 Teaching

"Adam has been very dedicated to teaching the data science classes, but he seems indifferent to the needs of DPPA students."—fundamentally, there is a cross-department friction here: Patrice does not want me to teach data science students. But data science is my strength and we have a new data science program that I am supporting—I don't think I should be penalized for supporting another program. Importantly, the good news now for even most coding-averse DPPA students is AI that can write the code for them, so it should be all fixed (as of 2025 seems to be great), but let's revisit in some time what's best for students.

In teaching section Patrice cherry picks negative student evaluations out of mostly positive ones. To be sure, I did take those into account long time ago when I saw them—fixed up Canvas, organized better. I do take teaching seriously.

And I strive to improve my teaching—no need for Patrice to tell me that. For instance, I just attended cybersecurity trainings⁸, and attended Instructional Design and Technology (IDT) workshop on "Crafting the Learner-Centered Syllabus" in 2024. And I quite regularly read on teaching and mentoring advice, tips and tricks on [nature.com](https://www.nature.com), [chronicle.com](https://www.chronicle.com), and [insidehighered.com](https://www.insidehighered.com).

3 Service

"I would like to see a stronger level of service to the department"—I heard that 3 years ago when department denied support for my promotion due to poor departmental service⁹—so I asked what else can I do for the department. I did everything I was asked to do, and more, I did extra things I wasn't asked (see CV for my service details), in fact I went to Patrice every semester to check on service. Last year, on 2025-10-20 Mon, I met with Patrice, I went over my service from my CV, and she did say "the service is ok."¹⁰ No comments.

Just briefly to respond to the things Patrice says I should be doing. "There are opportunities to take on a greater leadership role in several areas, including:"

- "Advising doctoral students" "Guiding dissertations and working collaboratively with other committee members"—that's funny! I supervise 5. The departmental recommendation is 3. So there is no thanks for going above and beyond, and apparently I don't do enough. In addition I am supervising master theses in Data Science, and I do many independent studies—in fact I think I'm doing more than anybody else in the department here. Over past 6 years 2020-2026, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social sciences, and supervised 15 independent studies.
- "Assisting the department with: data dashboards, graduation rates for students, data collection"—that sounds like institutional research, not a part of my job description.
- "assisting with data from affiliated centers"—Patrice seems to ask that I work for Gloria's and Steve's centers apparently for free. I don't believe it's in my job description. However, I'm always happy to do paid consulting. (Gloria would have to pay upfront to avoid problems from the past).
- "Workshops for PhD Students"—I do those occasionally, e.g., "Publish or Perish—how to publish" and did GIS workshop. I was doing regularly brown bags, but Patrice told me we don't need them, now apparently she changed her mind, so happy to do those again.
- "Data Mentoring"—I don't know what that means, I guess that's what I do in my classes and with students that I advise, I don't see where else I should be doing it.

⁸2026 KnowBe4 Security Awareness Training, Cybersecurity Essentials: Secure Passwords, and Introduction to IT Security Policies—these enhance my classroom teaching—most of my courses involve computer coding or data science—cybersecurity matters more there than in usual social science courses.

⁹Which was also surprising at the time as I was doing what I was asked to do. But I thought then maybe I need to be more pro-active, don't wait to be told what to do, and do extra things. I also promised myself that this won't happen again, and I focused on service over past 3 years (see CV) at the cost to my research—I was devastated my research has suffered (research is my main thing, the reason I'm in academia) but I thought at least I'm sure I have fixed my service. But here we go again!

¹⁰I am 100% sure: I wrote it down along with the date.

"he submitted questions that had been posted online and could not be used."—Paul did the same, i.e., used published papers in exam questions. I might have occasionally used/re-used questions from the past—my understanding was that it was fine as long as it is not all of the questions and not from prior year. "He appeared to put little time or effort into his work on the MS/PHD committee."—I am efficient and productive.

4 Research

My favorite section. "There is room for improvement"—wow. I was asked not to compare and not to be personal, so no names, just overall department stats.

Research impact or visibility is commonly measured with citations, and I am the most cited person in the department, by large margin. As of May 11 2026, I'm cited exactly 2x the second best person in the department this year.

Quantity of research output is measured at [researchwithrutgers.com](https://www.researchwithrutgers.com) (appears to be down as of May 15 2026, but the underlying data are at scopus.com)—both at research units/department level and employee level. The department (research unit: Graduate School, Camden: Public Policy and Administration) has 10 employees.¹¹ Over the years 2019-2022¹² the 10 employees of the department have produced 37 research outputs,¹³ out of which 17 were mine,¹⁴ i.e., I have produced about half of the 10 person unit's output.¹⁵

2023-May 2026, the department has produced 33 outputs, out of which 13 are mine—I have been burdened with unfair amount of service over past 3 years, but still I have produced 40% of the department's output.

Visibility (and arguably quality and competitiveness) of the research output can be measured as Impact Factor (IF). I'm pretty sure there are only 2 people in this 10-person department that consistently publish in high impact journals, I am one of them. Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1.

And the department chair tells me "there is room for improvement." I would refrain from further comments to end it on a positive note.

5 Conclusion and Discussion

It's time for new blood and new leadership in DPPA. I would like to volunteer to be a department chair. This department can do well.¹⁶

Or at least let's capitalize on my research strengths. I see myself as a research leader in the department—I'm not only productive myself in research, but also I lead the students in research. My students publish.¹⁷ I would like take on more leadership in research, for instance, I would like to take students to ISQOLS conference.¹⁸ I could also take on more administrative roles, for instance take the lead of the PhD program (if we can agree to focus more on science and less on activism).

I offer many more ideas in the section below.

¹¹<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/persons/>

¹²I took these from my merit pay which I wrote Nov15 2023.

¹³<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/publications>

¹⁴<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/persons/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/publications/>

¹⁵Of course, the measure is crude and simplistic as it doesn't differentiate research output's length and quality. Still, it is remarkable that over 4 years one person has produced as much as other 9 people. And on quality, too, as measured by Impact Factor of journals, there are only 2 people in the department publishing in high impact journals, I am one of them.

¹⁶Let's have more democracy, where non-full professors' voices are heard. Let's make sure people can grow, and pursue their own path. For instance, let's capitalize on my data science strength in teaching—we already started doing that and let's continue. I'm better fit to teach data science than regional economic development or quantitative methods that should be modernized and redesigned towards data science. I can make the case that data science (and Python, not Qgis or Stata) is the future and benefits our students. I am mindful of the fact that some DPPA students have struggled in the past, but now with AI that should not be a problem anymore.

¹⁷Since 2020, we have published 10 peer-reviewed papers with my students in good journals including 3 in top ranked *Cities* with Impact Factor of 8.1. I co-edit *Social Indicators Research*—this also benefits our students—I have mentored 2 students to publish in the journal, and I involve the students also in the reviewing process for the journal.

¹⁸We should not prioritize the UAA conference—our research strengths do not lie there.

6 Questions to Patrice and Answers

- The evaluation is mostly unhelpful and unproductive—it's supposed to be about research/teaching/service and forward looking. Instead you bring up conflicts from the past. Look, I am trying to de-escalate here and get along, let's just drop that part about past conflicts and misunderstandings.

In addition your writeup puts DPPA in bad light, and some other people, too. If you don't drop the part about conflicts, then I have to respond to that as it goes on my file and it's a vicious cycle. I think you miss important things here, you put dirt not just on me, but also on department, Gloria and Paul and Mike, as you force me to respond and elaborate on what really happened here.

A: Patrice wants to keep that.

- Who wrote it? Gloria? Someone else? Just you or with input from someone?¹⁹ A: She wrote this.
- You understand you keep on writing non-factual/fake evaluations like my merit pay and this one? A: No response.
- Need examples? Service you said last year was ok, now you flipped to saying I need more. A: "You service to campus is very good, to discipline is strong." But maintain that to the department is not good.
- Can we agree to have factual, evidence-based evaluations?²⁰ A: Agreed we will be putting things in writing.
- I am also happy to be consulted and asked questions ahead of the evaluation, help out if anything is unclear. A: ""
- Can you also please respect conflict of interest for the future? Even perceived or potential only? Like with Paul's teaching evaluation. A: Couldn't agree here. Don't see conflict of interest there.
- You are not a serious person—you did say my service was good, now you flipped. Do you remember you did say, on 2025-10-20 Mon: "the service is ok"?²¹²² A: Patrice doesn't remember. We agreed going forward putting things in writing will be helpful.
- I've been given service for 14 years I'm here and I always agreed to everything, don't you think it is time for some initiative from my side and some flexibility? A: ""
- We should capitalize on my research strengths, I see myself as a research leader in the department, leading students, and publishing with them. A: ""
- For instance, I cannot do UAA pre-presentations, I don't know what this conference is about, but I am happy to do ISQOLS pre-presentations, that's where our research strength is. What do you think? A: Not sure if that's the best way.
- I can also do brown-bags, great you do not oppose to these anymore? A: Ok great agreed here, we will do brown bags.
- I don't think we need events/awards committee—it doesn't do much good, and what good it does is handled by Mike, you, and Lisa anyway. My role doesn't do much, just bureaucracy and unnecessary meetings. I was ok to chair it but can you please remove me from this committee, at least for a year?²³ A: "" Still I am doing a lot outside of the department, not for the department.
- Processing student data and doing stats for the dept is not a part of my job, that's institutional research. Agreed? A: ""

A: Doing more than 5 dissertations that I am doing now would not be good. A: 4 dissertation committee memberships is enough.

¹⁹I doesn't sound like Patrice.

²⁰This is at the core of the disagreement and conflict: evaluations are not factual.

²¹I am 100% sure I wrote it down along with the date.

²²Now you just said: ""I would like to see a stronger level of service to the department," that is, I do not do enough for the dept.

²³Importantly, now I just have too much other meaningful/important service: dissertations, MS theses, independent studies, visiting professor, AP committee, etc—see CV.

- You seem to be suggesting I do unpaid data work for Gloria's and Steve's centers? I don't believe it's in my job description either? A: ""
- I am happy to do paid data consulting. Or be part of grants, like with Clint. Don't you think it is a good idea? A: ""
- What workshops for PhDs do you have in mind (beyond brown bags)? For instance, I could do workshops on publishing, GIS, and maybe especially "finding the right data" may be most useful? Can we find some money for those in the budget? We could also perhaps split with other departments? A: ""
- I can do more administrative work for the department. Can I be a chair? A: "" Patrice was laughing.
- I can also head PhD? Can we agree to focus on science, not activism? A: ""
- Teaching—we have AI, now even least able people can write code, so Python is actually easier than Stata or Qgis, lets revisit next year how it goes? A: ""
- Do you want me to make the case for Python? A: ""
- Also, can we redesign PhD towards data science, so it fits better our faculty? For instance, let's drop Regional Economic Development and make a data science class required? A: ""

[in general, let's give people some voice, and re-design existing structures around current people—for instance Regional Economic Development was probably put there 20 years ago when we had someone socializing in that, let's redesign now towards data science]

- We can also redesign QM1 and QM2 towards data science and can I teach those? Or replace QM1 with data visualization at least? A: ""
- Canvas and syllabi were made perfectly clear long time ago, anything else? Want to have a look if anything missing there? You can get back with me later. A: ""
- Reseach-Did you read my papers? Which ones? A: Patrice read some of my research.
- Or Paul wrote this part of evaluation? He didn't read my papers either—they say what affects happiness in cities, and there are policy implications. Or do I miss something? A: ""
- I think what happened here, is that Paul or you do not like the quality of my research? Or find some elements missing? A: ""
- But you are NOT experts in my area, that's why we use external reviewers who are experts. Are you positioned well to evaluate my research? Why would you think so? A: ""
- Do you publish on happiness? Do you publish in similar journals? A: ""
- Why would you read my research, and not just use scientometrics? A: ""
- Do I underperform on any scientometrics? A: ""
- Do I have a right to conduct independent research? A: ""
- Isn't telling me to change my research, for instance Paul was pushing for instrumental variables, invading my right to academic freedom? A: ""
- Can I make it clear that I do not welcome Paul's research advice? A: ""
- How come my research is not evaluated as exceeding expectations? What are the expectations? A: ""
- What is missing? Is the topic bad? Or bad journals? A: ""

7 Appendix: asked Patrice to rewrite



Re: Post Tenure Review

From Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>

Date Thu 5/14/2026 7:28 PM

To Patrice Mareschal <marescha@camden.rutgers.edu>

by the way, speaking of AI wonders here's an AI summary:

Here's a clear, concise summary of your email [Re: Post Tenure Review](#):

Purpose

You propose a call with Patrice Mareschal and outline how to revise and frame your post-tenure review discussion.

Main Points**1. Tone and Strategy**

- Suggest removing contentious issues (lawsuits, Paul's evaluation).
- Recommend a more constructive, de-escalated message emphasizing respectful communication for the benefit of students and the department.

2. Teaching

- Defend the value of teaching Python to DPPA students.
- Argue it is highly practical (students using it in jobs, research).
- Emphasize that AI tools make Python accessible.
- Offer to provide evidence and additional support (labs, extra time).

3. Service

- Push back on claims of insufficient service.
- State that your contributions may be undercounted.
- Highlight heavy workload (multiple dissertations, mentoring, visiting faculty support).
- Propose new initiatives (data workshops, brown bags, research gatherings, possibly rethinking PhD structure).

4. Research

- Express strong frustration that your research is undervalued.
- Emphasize both quantity and quality (publications, citations, editorial board).
- Position yourself as a research leader who collaborates with students.

5. Conflict with Paul (Research Philosophy)

- Strongly object to pressure to pursue causal methods.
- Assert your right to independent research direction.
- Argue that:
 - Causality is only one valid approach.
 - Your field (urbanism) does not typically use causal designs.
 - Many top publications rely on ideas and data rather than causal methods.
- Emphasize that evaluation should rely on external reviewers and field standards, not internal opinions outside the field.

6. Overall Ask

- Request a fair evaluation grounded in:
 - External review letters
 - Field-specific standards
 - Recognized metrics (impact, journals, citations)

Tone

- Candid, detailed, and at times emotional
 - Mix of conciliatory intent (toward Patrice) and strong defense (against Paul's critique)
-

From: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>

Sent: Thursday, May 14, 2026 7:21 PM

To: Patrice Mareschal <marescha@camden.rutgers.edu>

Subject: Re: Post Tenure Review

hi Patrice, sorry about the delay, blocked off couple days for research and tenure packet without email, how's tomorrow (fri)? pick a time

in a nutshell:

-i think we should drop the part about lawsuits and paul's teaching evaluation; instead we can de-escalate, and say something constructive and productive along these lines: "despite past conflicts and miscommunications, we have agreed for friendly and respectful communication for the benefit of students and department"—i mean it and i will make every effort to do it

-in teaching: i am NOT indifferent to DPPA students (v data science), happy to explain more, but real quick: many DPPA students benefit greatly from python, notably erick watt udogu, not just for his research, but notably for his administrative job--he's using it every day and contributes greatly to the campus with Python from my class; shirley and benito just registered for more python classes, etc etc; importantly, now there is AI built-in, one does not need to write the code, just ask AI to do it, it makes it easier immensely, it does wonders—i strongly believe it makes Python very accessible, as much as stata and qgis if not more, and looking into the future we would make our students a disservice if we dont teach them the latest and greatest tools; im happy to provide evidence and make the case, just real quick here is an accesible read: <https://www.theatlantic.com/science/archive/2018/04/the-scientific-paper-is-obsolete/556676/> ; i can also do extra labs and spend extra time outside of classroom to get students up to the speed!

-service--i think you have missed many service items from my cv; i think it is unfair to say i have not been doing enough, i don't ask you to say it's excellent, but i think it was at least ok or good enough, lets

discuss more, and sure there are couple things more i would like to do; i think one problem and frustration was that i was just assigned service, but i have couple great ideas for service that i would like to do and i think would benefit department greatly, eg 'how to find data' workshops or phds, regular brown bags, semi-informal research get-togethers like faculty-student mixer, but about research—we could go to nuanced and talk about research over coffee; last but not least i'd be happy to run phd if we can agree to drop exams (eg prevention science doesn't have them) and say have a publishable paper requirement or at least limit these exams (if paul wants to administer them fine); i see myself as research leader—I'm not only very productive in research myself but also lead students—over past 6 years published 10 papers with students including 3 in high impact cities—I involve students in reviewing papers for social indicators research, i mentored 2 students to publish in social indicators research—I think we should capitalize more on my research strengths

-research--this has been maybe the source of my greatest frustration over past few years, i feel that for some reason the department doesn't appreciate my research contributions; i don't think it's just quantity, but also quality!--i consistently publish in quality high impact journals, i've been elected to the editorial board for social indicators research, my work is highly cited, etc etc

per paul—may skip this--lots of ideas here and rambling a bit, but in case you wanted more info here: i might have over-reacted slightly, but the thing is he's NOT in my research area, and however well-intentioned his advice might have been, it was NOT helpful; i have a right to do independent research—paul has no right to tell me what kind of research i need to do, i think it stems from the fact that i have been his student 20 years ago, but i am not anymore; we don't really do causality in my area of research, we do not do experiments (neither does paul! if you haven't done it yourself don't ask others--this is a fun fact that got lost somewhere--my research is more methodologically advanced than his--i'm using regressions, he just has tables of descriptive statistics); he is always pushing me to do instrumental variables, it's not a great idea, it may work out, maybe at some point, but saying or implying i have to do it to get his vote to be promoted is not right—I welcome comments and collegiality, but he is really pushing it and forcing it—I do not welcome such advice, i want to make this clear

paul is not fundamentally wrong in grand scheme of things—indeed causality is one way to contribute—agreed; but is **just one of many ways!** it's neither necessary nor sufficient for great research!!; and this is not the way i have chosen to contribute in my research, and i have a right to be an independent researcher; i may do causality at some point if i decide so, and it is my decision, not his; his right is to vote however he wants on my promotion, but again i do not welcome paul pushing on me his causality advice

i am contributing in different ways than causality (most social science research is not causal by the way!); i have novel ideas and able to find the right data to test them—I use complex large scale datasets to study new relationships—this is my contribution as recognized by my field; then someone may come and maybe do causal research building on my work and that would be her contribution, but i have contributed, too—if i haven't i wouldn't be publishing in high impact journals, but i do

by the way some of the greatest research out there in the very top journals like nature or science is NOT causal, it's just a data visualization like a scatterplot, and yet it is the top of the top, cream of the crop research, that beats any other research causal or not; so don't tell me that for a research piece to be good it has to be causal—it is simply not true! it just frustrates me a ton, paul seems to really believe what he is saying, but he is just wrong here, and doesn't even want to be open to changing his mind; and this very top research in nature or science—what makes it the very top is the research idea and the right data NOT causality, this is what i aspire to, and this is my research strength and direction—novel ground

breaking research ideas and great data WITHOUT causality; if paul thinks nature or science papers are not good because they are not causal, i dont know what to say

paul himself has never done any causal research and he is a full professor, don't tell me to do something you havent done yourself, especially regarding promotion--again sure we can one day sit together have a coffee and do some causal research at some point but i strongly dont believe this is a requirement for promotion; one problem with paul's ideas is that he is in education area where causality is important; my area is urbanism;

urbanism is my independent variable--it can hardly be studied in a causal way, it is an organic process in the real world, almost all research in this area, my area of research, is not causal

yet another point, last one, i could go on for more believe me, but for sake of time, economists (like paul) also have it wrong that complex stats and econometrics and instrumental variables etc give you causality; no they don't! they just get you little closer if done right, but the only way to claim causality is experiments or quasi experiments; causality is not about stats or models, it is about research design; so if you want to do causality right in my area of effect of cities on happiness, you would have to assign people at random to cities and rural areas—it's impossible it doesnt make any sense

anyway, lets agree to disagree here, and i am only asking you to facilitate a fair evaluation and just please read the external letters from my field and see what the experts in my field say

and i think in general the role of full professors in the dept is just to read external letters of experts in my field, not read the research itself; you can also look at metrics such as impact factors, journal rankings, citations, etc; but it is problematic to evaluate research in not one's area—paul doesn't study happiness neither publish in journals that i publish, so he doesnt know standards of my field—thats why we have external reviewers

i think i know what i am saying here i've been on like 10 A&P cases, i have chaired like 5 cases—we don't force our research ideas on the candidate, don't read the research and evaluate it, because it is not our field! if paul was studying effect of urban-rural gradient on happiness and published in cities, social indicators research and applied research in quality of life, we would understand each other better; but he was my stats professor 20 years ago and he still thinks he is

cheers and talk soon!

From: Patrice Mareschal <marescha@camden.rutgers.edu>

Sent: Sunday, May 10, 2026 2:43 PM

To: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>

Subject: Re: Post Tenure Review

Hi Adam,

Let's schedule a time this week to discuss the review process and my comments . I am available:

- Monday, May 11, 3:30pm-5:00pm
- Tuesday, May 12, 10:00am-11:00am
- Wednesday, May 13, 3:30pm-5:00pm

8 Appendix: Paul's teaching evaluation and my response

Rutgers University-Camden
Department of Public Policy and Administration
Faculty Peer Evaluation of Classroom Teaching

Course:

- 56:219:521 DATA VISUALIZATION (dat sci)
- 56:824:728 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)
- 56:834:653 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)

Instructor: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn **Date Evaluated:** April 3, 2025

Note: Given the long time elapsed since the class observation, I supplemented my notes by watching the class video.

1. Subject of Class:

1) visualization techniques for data clustering, e.g. dendrograms and k-means scatterplots, 2) annotation of graphs using matplotlib, 3) “flipped classroom” to respond to student questions about a problem set.

2. Relevance of the subject to the course:

The content was appropriate to a course on data visualization, touching on important methods for representing clusters and relationships in data.

3. A. Was an assignment made: Yes _____ No ☒

Although no new assignment was introduced during the session, students appeared engaged with an assignment from the prior week and came prepared to discuss it.

B. Were students prepared: Yes ☒ No _____

4. Clarity of the ideas presented:

The description of the class as given to the students:

[apr3] clustering

a bit similar to previous scatterplots; clustering is about grouping / finding patterns, and very much data sciency!

we only scratch the surface here--just few popular vis for clustering;
i don't cover here the method, algorithms etc

Adam worked systematically through the material, alternating between code demonstrations in an online notebook and examples. The examples were presented clearly, but the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. For example, the class could have explored more explicitly when to use a dendrogram versus a scatterplot with k-means clustering. For another, an “elbow plot” was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes.

While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material.

5. Manner of delivery:

Adam put students at ease and was very responsive to student questions. He made good use of examples, both simple examples using a small dataset followed by more complete examples using graphics from published papers.

6. Effective use of teaching aide(s), if they apply:

Rather than a whiteboard or PowerPoint slides, Adam used an online coding notebook, an environment for writing and executing code. This is an appropriate format given the material and the emphasis on coding. However, the notebook’s structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing.

7. Student participation: The students were engaged throughout and asked appropriate questions. Adam had a good rapport with the students. When students sought deeper conceptual explanations (e.g., how clustering algorithms work), the responses could have gone beyond general descriptions to help students better understand the mechanics and assumptions of these techniques.

8: Other comments:

The syllabus and class notes would benefit from more careful organization and editing. Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program.

More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully.

Adam’s course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning

environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn *how* to make various chart but not *why* certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively.

Paul A. Jorgensen

Visitor: _____

Date: 11/11/2025 Instructor: Bob Olin-Kay Date: _____
nov21 2025

Acceptance or comments:

The evaluation was helpful as it made me realize that my html bullet points didn't render and thus obscured readability; and it got me thinking about spending less time on code as AI takes over. Other than that the evaluation was unhelpful. I would like to raise several issues so that we can do better in the future.

Paul does not teach Python or data visualization. Neither does he use Python in his research. I was arguing to have someone else evaluate my teaching. I even found a replacement to do evaluation. Then I can't get the evaluation for 7 months (class was in April, I get evaluation in November) despite multiple emails and reminders. And then evaluation is mostly unhelpful as outlined below with my inline responses.

"the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. "

It's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"an "elbow plot" was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes."

That's the whole point of the "elbow plot" to tell the number of groups. Again, it's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material."

No. There is a reference to a specific chapter: "and especially machine learning ch: <https://jakevdp.github.io/PythonDataScienceHandbook/05.00-machine-learning.html>"

"the notebook's structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the

material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing."

There are not only section headings, but there are 3 levels of them: chapters, sections, and sub-sections (and I even police this in students' assignments—I take points off if students don't use sections).

"Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program."

I was trying to discuss and get a sense of what Paul means here but I wasn't able to get detailed or specific information. As far as I can tell it's about writing style: Paul is traditional and formal. And I'm quite the opposite: modern, straightforward, and informal.

My materials have a clear structure and consistent format. I actually have a specific philosophy here to be straightforward and informal. I follow Zinnser's "On Writing Well: The Essential Guide to Mastering Nonfiction Writing and Effective Communication." For instance: "Never say anything in writing that you wouldn't comfortably say in conversation. If you're not a person who says "indeed" or "moreover," or who calls someone an individual ("he's a fine individual"), please don't write it." I was asking Paul for reference to his style, but I didn't get any.

I even wrote a paper on cluttered and ornamented grandiose prose in social science as compared to natural science: <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11192-012-0937-9>

So called social science "professional presentation" in writing can typically actually obscure meaning and communication. Again, following Zinnser, the goal should be simplicity and readability.

Per "high standards of our program"--i think my teaching has a good standard, e.g., my current students publish in good journals: https://theaok.github.io/okulicz_kozaryn_cv.pdf#page=6

And, what do we mean by "high standards of our program"? Is it formal traditional writing? Does such writing translate into desired outcomes, i.e. communication and learning? (especially in methods/coding classes). These are ever more relevant questions as we are increasingly over-burdened by information. Clarity, simplicity, and readability seem a way to go.

"More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully. Adam's course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn how to make various chart but not why certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively."

These were covered in the course earlier. The class was geared towards the students, not towards the visitation, i.e. the visited Apr3 class was not self-contained, it did not include important elements included in other classes.

I did reach out to Paul to discuss, build bridges, and understand each other better. We had 2 discussions, somewhat helpful, but still I was not able to get enough details and specificity. I got a sense that it is time to wrap up, hence my lengthy response above. For the future, I am hoping we can agree to disagree and work out constructive compromises.

The evaluation was also helpful in a sense that I watched the class video and noted I could have had a little more eye contact and walk around more and be less on the monitor. But again as outlined above most of the evaluation is unhelpful--I hope in the future we can be more constructive. I am excited to discuss and collaborate on teaching. I think we could focus more on teaching.

Rev. 1/12